

Notes: Eisensee and Strömberg (QJE, 2007)

News Droughts, News Floods, and U.S. Disaster Relief

Contents

1	One-sentence summary	2
2	Big picture	2
2.1	Research question	2
2.2	Core empirical problem	2
2.3	Identification idea	2
2.4	Main result	2
2.5	Broad implication	2
3	Incremental contribution of the paper	2
3.1	A credible media-effect design	2
3.2	A policy outcome with direct welfare relevance	2
3.3	A new crowd-out mechanism	3
3.4	A bridge between agenda setting and public finance	3
3.5	A measurement contribution	3
3.6	A bias quantification contribution	3
4	Data and measurement	3
4.1	Disaster sample	3
4.2	Relief measure	3
4.3	News coverage measure	3
4.4	News-pressure instruments	3
4.5	Controls and severity variables	4
5	Empirical specifications and identification	4
5.1	Reduced-form news and relief regressions	4
5.2	First stage	4
5.3	Second stage	4
5.4	Identifying assumptions	4
5.5	Balance and exclusion checks	4
5.6	Limitations	5
6	Mechanism and economic intuition	5
6.1	The signal extraction problem	5
6.2	The crowd-out channel	5
6.3	The policy response channel	5
6.4	Why this creates bias	5

7	Tables and figures	5
7.1	Table I: Summary Statistics and Table II: Summary Statistics for Disasters	5
7.2	Figure I: News stories on disasters, by days from the disaster and Figure II: Daily Number News Stories about Olympic Games, 1992	6
7.3	Figure III: Daily news pressure and Table III: The Largest Daily News Pressure Dates and Main Story, by Year	6
7.4	Figure IV: News Pressure during 405 Days, March 15, 2001-April 23, 2002 and Table IV: Effect of the Pressure for News Time on Disaster News and Relief	8
7.5	Table V: Correlations between Instruments and the Severity of Disasters and Figure V: Predicted Probability of a Disaster being in the News and Actual Share of Disasters Receiving Relief	8
7.6	Table VI: News and Relief and Table VII: Robustness	9
7.7	Table VIII: Newsworthiness of Disasters, by Disaster Type and Table IX: Newsworthiness of Disasters, by Continents	10
7.8	Table X: News Broadcasts on August 5, 1968	11
8	Short summary	11
9	Conclusion	12
9.1	Core conclusion	12
9.2	Incremental contribution revisited	12
9.3	Economic intuition	12
9.4	Policy implication	12
9.5	Limitations	12
9.6	Takeaway	12

1 One-sentence summary

Eisensee and Strömberg show that U.S. disaster relief to foreign natural disasters is partly driven by whether disasters receive television news coverage, and that unrelated news events such as the Olympics crowd out disaster coverage and reduce the probability of relief.

2 Big picture

2.1 Research question

Does mass media coverage causally influence U.S. government disaster relief, or is coverage merely correlated with underlying disaster severity and political salience?

2.2 Core empirical problem

News coverage and policy responses are jointly determined. Disasters that are more severe or politically salient are both more likely to be covered and more likely to receive relief. A simple regression of relief on news coverage would therefore overstate the causal effect of news.

2.3 Identification idea

The paper exploits the availability of other newsworthy material. If a natural disaster occurs during the Olympic Games or during a day crowded by other major news, television news has less time to cover the disaster. These competing stories are unrelated to the severity of foreign natural disasters, so they provide plausibly exogenous variation in disaster news coverage.

2.4 Main result

News pressure reduces disaster coverage and reduces the probability of U.S. relief. Instrumental variables estimates imply that coverage has a large positive effect on relief decisions.

2.5 Broad implication

Relief is not allocated only by need. It is also affected by media scarcity. This generates systematic bias across disaster types and regions because some disasters are more newsworthy than others.

3 Incremental contribution of the paper

3.1 A credible media-effect design

The paper moves beyond correlations between media coverage and policy. It uses unrelated competing news stories as instruments for disaster coverage, making the empirical design much closer to a causal test of media influence.

3.2 A policy outcome with direct welfare relevance

The outcome is not attitudes, voting, or media attention alone. It is U.S. disaster relief for foreign victims. The paper therefore connects media economics to a real allocation of government resources.

3.3 A new crowd-out mechanism

The paper formalizes the idea of a fixed television news budget. News about one event crowds out news about another. This means that even important events can fail to receive policy attention when unrelated events occupy the news agenda.

3.4 A bridge between agenda setting and public finance

The empirical results show that media agenda setting can affect fiscal allocations. Disaster relief is partly a function of what appears on evening news programs.

3.5 A measurement contribution

The authors combine multiple datasets: CRED disaster data, Vanderbilt television news data, OFDA relief records, and constructed measures of news pressure from the Olympics and major news events.

3.6 A bias quantification contribution

The paper quantifies how newsworthiness differs by disaster type and continent. For example, some disasters need far more deaths than others to obtain the same coverage probability.

4 Data and measurement

4.1 Disaster sample

The main disaster sample comes from the Centre for Research on the Epidemiology of Disasters. It covers roughly 5,000 foreign natural disasters from 1968 to 2002. Disasters include droughts, earthquakes, floods, storms, volcanoes, slides, fires, epidemics, infestations, and other disaster categories.

4.2 Relief measure

Relief is measured using USAID Office of Foreign Disaster Assistance records. The key binary outcome is whether a disaster receives U.S. relief or a disaster declaration.

4.3 News coverage measure

Disaster news coverage comes from the Vanderbilt Television News Archive. The key variable equals one if a disaster is covered in U.S. network evening news within a relevant time window around the disaster.

4.4 News-pressure instruments

The paper constructs two instruments:

- **Olympics instrument:** whether the disaster occurs near Olympic Games days, weighted by the empirical timing of disaster coverage.
- **General news pressure:** the amount of other newsworthy material in network news broadcasts, also weighted by the timing distribution of disaster coverage.

4.5 Controls and severity variables

The regressions control for disaster severity, including deaths and affected population. They also include fixed effects such as disaster type, country, year, and month, depending on the specification.

5 Empirical specifications and identification

5.1 Reduced-form news and relief regressions

The reduced-form specification asks whether news pressure directly predicts disaster coverage and relief:

$$Y_{ict} = \alpha + \beta NewsPressure_t + \gamma Severity_{ict} + FE + \varepsilon_{ict},$$

where Y is either disaster news coverage or relief.

Interpretation: A negative coefficient on news pressure means that unrelated news crowds out disaster coverage or relief.

5.2 First stage

The first stage predicts disaster coverage using the availability of other news:

$$News_{ict} = \alpha + \pi Z_t + \gamma Severity_{ict} + FE + u_{ict},$$

where Z_t is either the Olympics instrument or general news pressure.

Interpretation: The first stage captures the fixed-time-budget logic of television news. When other news is abundant, disasters are less likely to be covered.

5.3 Second stage

The IV equation estimates the effect of news coverage on relief:

$$Relief_{ict} = \alpha + \delta \widehat{News}_{ict} + \gamma Severity_{ict} + FE + e_{ict}.$$

Interpretation: The IV coefficient asks how relief changes when a disaster is covered because it faces less news competition, not because it is more severe.

5.4 Identifying assumptions

The key assumption is that Olympics timing and unrelated news pressure affect U.S. disaster relief only by changing disaster news coverage, not through disaster severity or direct policy channels.

5.5 Balance and exclusion checks

The authors show that the instruments are not meaningfully correlated with deaths, affected population, or other severity measures. This strengthens the claim that the instruments shift media coverage rather than disaster need.

5.6 Limitations

The instruments estimate a local average treatment effect for disasters whose coverage is affected by news crowd-out. They do not measure every possible effect of media on policy, and the exclusion restriction is most credible for events like the Olympics that are clearly unrelated to foreign disasters.

6 Mechanism and economic intuition

6.1 The signal extraction problem

Government officials may not observe all foreign disasters with equal intensity. Television news acts as an information and salience channel, telling officials and voters which disasters deserve attention.

6.2 The crowd-out channel

Even if a disaster is severe, it may be missed by television news when other events dominate the news agenda. Since television news time is fixed, other stories create an opportunity cost of disaster coverage.

6.3 The policy response channel

If officials care about voter attention, bureaucratic salience, or public pressure, they are more likely to allocate relief when a disaster is on the news. This produces a causal path:

$$Other\ News \uparrow \Rightarrow Disaster\ Coverage \downarrow \Rightarrow Relief \downarrow .$$

6.4 Why this creates bias

Some disasters are inherently more visually dramatic or newsworthy than others. A volcano may receive coverage with fewer deaths than a drought. Therefore media effects generate systematic distortions in humanitarian relief.

7 Tables and figures

7.1 Table I: Summary Statistics and Table II: Summary Statistics for Disasters

Read: Table I summarizes the main sample: about 19 percent of disasters receive relief and about 12 percent receive news coverage. Table II breaks disasters down by type, showing large differences in frequency, deaths, affected population, and relief probability.

Economic message: The paper begins by showing that relief and news coverage are both rare events. It also shows that disaster types are very different in severity and relief incidence, so disaster-type controls are necessary.

Variable	Observations	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Relief	5,212	0.19	0.39	0	1
News	5,212	0.12	0.32	0	1
Killed	3,714	590	9,143	1	300,000
Affected	4,004	1,092,508	9,858,292	1	300,000,000
News pressure	5,212	7.73	1.22	4.56	14.32
Olympics	5,212	0.02	0.09	0	0.77
World series	5,212	0.01	0.05	0	0.56

(a) Table I: Summary Statistics.

Disaster type	Number of disasters	Share of disasters	Killed per disaster	Affected per disaster	Share receiving OFDA relief
Flood	1,675	0.32	170	1,724,851	0.22
Storm	1,175	0.23	646	601,490	0.17
Epidemic	737	0.14	249	27,528	0.12
Earthquake	559	0.11	1,522	173,015	0.21
Drought	326	0.06	18,657	5,740,623	0.30
Landslide	310	0.06	84	38,789	0.06
Fire	129	0.02	19	69,552	0.13
Cold wave	114	0.02	103	46,656	0.01

(b) Table II: Summary Statistics for Disasters.

These tables establish the sample size, the rarity of relief/news, and the heterogeneity of disasters by type.

7.2 Figure I: News stories on disasters, by days from the disaster and Figure II: Daily Number News Stories about Olympic Games, 1992

Read: Figure I shows that disaster stories are usually aired in the first few days after the event. Figure II shows that Olympics news is concentrated during Olympic dates.

Economic message: These two timing facts justify the weighted Olympic instrument: the relevant crowd-out window is the period when disaster coverage is most likely to occur.

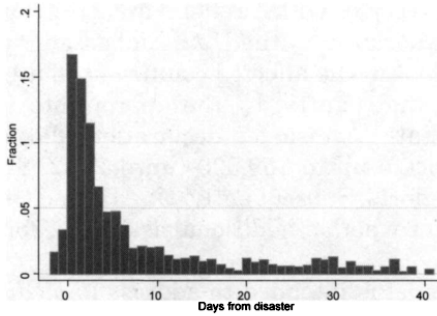


FIGURE I

News stories on disasters, by days from the disaster

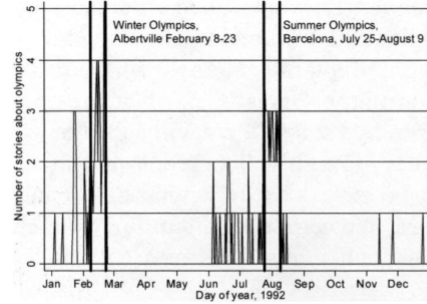


FIGURE II

Daily Number News Stories about Olympic Games, 1992

(a) Figure I: News stories on disasters, by days from the disaster.

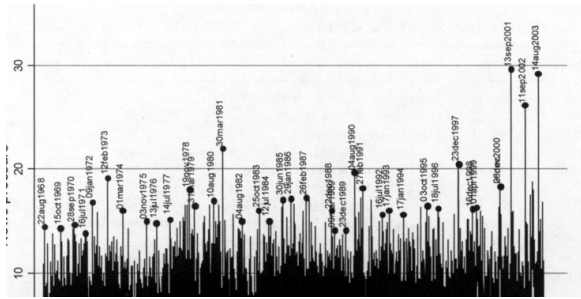
(b) Figure II: Daily Number News Stories about Olympic Games, 1992.

The two figures jointly motivate the timing and weighting of the Olympic crowd-out instrument.

7.3 Figure III: Daily news pressure and Table III: The Largest Daily News Pressure Dates and Main Story, by Year

Read: Figure III shows time-series spikes in news pressure. Table III lists the largest news-pressure days by year and the dominant story on those days.

Economic message: This validates the general news-pressure measure. High news-pressure days correspond to obvious major events such as wars, political shocks, accidents, and major public events.



(a) Figure III: Daily news pressure.

TABLE III
TWO LARGEST DAILY NEWS PRESSURE DATES AND MAIN STORY, BY YEAR

Year	Date	Main news story
2003	Aug 14	New York City Blackout
	Mar 22	Invasion of Iraq: Day 3
2002	Sep 11	9/11 Commemoration
	Oct 24	Sniper Shooting in Washington: Arrest of Suspects
2001	Sep 13	9/11 Attack on America: Day 3
	Sep 12	9/11 Attack on America: Day 2
2000	Nov 26	Gore vs. Bush: Florida Recount—Certification by Katherine Harris
	Dec 8	Gore vs. Bush: Florida Recount—Supreme Court Ruling
1999	Apr 1	Kosovo Crisis: U. S. Soldiers Captured
	Jul 18	Crash of Plane Carrying John F. Kennedy, Junior
1998	Dec 16	U. S. Missile Attack on Iraq
	Dec 18	Clinton Impeachment
1997	Dec 23	Oklahoma City Bombing: Trial
	Aug 31	Princess Diana's Death
1996	Jul 18	TWA Flight 800 Explosion
	Jul 27	Olympic Games Bombing in Atlanta
1995	Oct 3	O.J. Simpson Trial: The Verdict
	Apr 22	Oklahoma City Bombing
1994	Jan 17	California Earthquake
	Jun 18	O.J. Simpson Arrested
1993	Jan 17	U. S. Missile Attack on Iraq
	Apr 20	Waco, Texas: Cult Standoff Ends in Fire
1992	Jul 16	Perot Quits 1992 Presidential Campaign
	May 1	Los Angeles Riots
1991	Feb 27	Gulf War: President Bush Declares Kuwait Liberated
	Jan 17	Gulf War: Operation Desert Storm Launched
1990	Aug 4	Iraq Invasion of Kuwait: Day 4
	Aug 8	Iraq Invasion of Kuwait: Mobilisation of U. S. Troops
1989	Mar 9	Senate Rejection of Tower Appointment to Secretary of Defence
	Dec 23	Romania Revolution
1988	Dec 22	Pan Am Plane Crash
	Dec 14	Arafat Condemns Terrorism and Accept Israel's Right to Exist
1987	26 Feb	Iran Arms Scandal: Tower Commission Report
	May 18	USS Stark Attack in Persian Gulf
1986	Jan 29	Challenger Explosion
	Apr 15	U. S. Attack on Libya
1985	Jun 30	TWA Flight 847 Hijacking: Release of Hostages
	Jun 29	TWA Flight 847 Hijacking: Release of Hostages
1984	Jul 12	Ferraro as Vice President Candidate
	Aug 16	Delorean Verdict
1983	Oct 25	U. S. Invasion of Grenada: Day 1
	Sep 3	USSR Downing of Korean Commercial Flight
1982	Aug 4	Israel Invasion of Lebanon
	Jan 2	Poland: Martial Law

(b) Table III: largest daily news pressure dates, part 1.

This pair shows that measured news pressure captures genuine competing news events.

TABLE III
(CONTINUED)

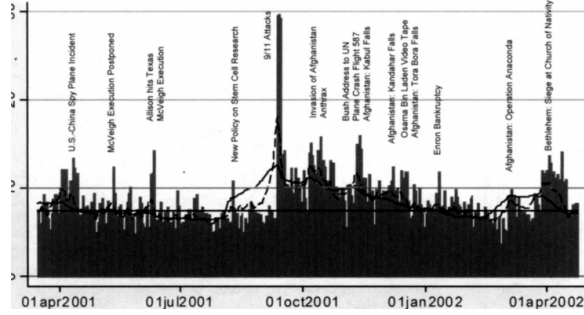
Year	Date	Main News Story
1978	Nov 19	Guyana Incident: Sect Mass Suicide
	Aug 6	Death of Pope Paul VI
1977	Jul 14	New York City Blackout
	Aug 11	Serial Killer David Berkowitz Arrested
1976	Jul 13	Democratic Convention
	Jun 9	Jimmy Carter Wins in Primaries
1975	Nov 3	Nelson Rockefeller Decides Not to Run for Vice President
	May 14	Mayaguez Incident: U. S. Attacks
1974	Mar 1	Watergate Indictments Announced
	Jul 21	Turkey Invades Cyprus
1973	Feb 12	Vietnam War: U. S. Prisoners of War Released
	Jan 24	Vietnam War: Cease-Fire Agreement Reached
1972	Jan 9	Howard Hughes Telephone Conference
	May 28	Nixon Visit in USSR: SALT I signed
1971	Jul 16	Nixon Announces Trip to China
	Aug 16	Nixon Suspends Convertibility from Dollars to Gold
1970	Sep 28	Gamal Abdel Nasser Dead
	Sep 7	Dawson's Field Hijackings: Blow Up of Planes
1969	Oct 15	Vietnam Anti-War Demonstration (Moratorium)
	Mar 28	Eisenhower Dead
1968	Aug 22	USSR Invades Czechoslovakia: Day 2
	Nov 1	October Surprise: Vietnam Bombing Halt

Table III continued: additional largest news-pressure dates and main stories.

7.4 Figure IV: News Pressure during 405 Days, March 15, 2001-April 23, 2002 and Table IV: Effect of the Pressure for News Time on Disaster News and Relief

Read: Figure IV shows the distribution and spikes of news pressure around major events. Table IV estimates how news pressure and Olympics timing affect both coverage and relief.

Economic message: Table IV is the reduced-form core of the paper. Competing news reduces disaster coverage and also reduces the chance of relief.



(a) Figure IV: News pressure over 405 days.

	Dependent variable: <i>News</i>				Dependent variable: <i>Relief</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
<i>News Pressure</i>	-0.0162 (0.0041)***	-0.0163 (0.0041)***	-0.0177 (0.0057)***	-0.0142 (0.0037)***	-0.0117 (0.0045)***	-0.0119 (0.0045)***	-0.0094 (0.0058)	-0.0078 (0.0040)**
<i>Olympics</i>	-0.1078 (0.0470)**	-0.1079 (0.0470)**	-0.0871 (-0.0628)	-0.111 (0.0413)***	-0.1231 (0.0321)**	-0.1232 (0.0321)**	-0.1071 (0.0763)	-0.1098 (0.0479)**
<i>World Series</i>	-0.1133 (-0.1065)				-0.1324 (0.1031)			
<i>log Killed</i>			0.0605 (0.0040)***				0.0582 (0.0044)***	
<i>log Affected</i>			0.0123 (0.0024)***			0.0376		
<i>Imputed log Killed</i>				0.0491 (0.0034)***				0.0442 (0.0037)***
<i>Imputed log Affected</i>				0.0131 (0.0020)***				0.0394 (0.0020)***
Observations	5,212	5,212	2,926	5,212	5,212	5,212	2,926	5,212
R-squared	0.1799	0.1797	0.3624	0.2875	0.1991	0.1989	0.4115	0.3726

Linear probability OLS regressions. All regressions include year, month, country, and disaster type fixed effects. Regressions with imputed values (4 and 8) also include fixed effects for the interaction of missing values and disaster type. Robust standard errors in parentheses. * significant at 10 percent, ** significant at 5 percent, *** significant at 1 percent.

(b) Table IV: effect of news pressure on news and relief.

The figure documents the news-pressure variable; the table shows that it predicts both media coverage and relief outcomes.

7.5 Table V: Correlations between Instruments and the Severity of Disasters and Figure V: Predicted Probability of a Disaster being in the News and Actual Share of Disasters Receiving Relief

Read: Table V shows that the instruments are not systematically correlated with disaster severity. Figure V shows how relief changes with predicted news probability.

Economic message: Table V supports instrument validity. Figure V shows that media-induced relief effects are most relevant for disasters near the margin of receiving coverage.

TABLE V CORRELATIONS BETWEEN INSTRUMENTS AND THE SEVERITY OF DISASTERS		
	Dependent variable	
	<i>News pressure</i>	<i>Olympics</i>
<i>log Killed</i>	−0.0082 (0.0113)	0.0003 (0.0010)
<i>log Affected</i>	0.0005 (0.0068)	−0.0006 (0.0006)
<i>p-value: F-test of joint insignificance</i>	0.75 0.62	
Observations	5,212	5,212
R-squared	0.3110	0.2035

(a) Table V: correlations between instruments and disaster severity.

This pair combines instrument validity evidence with evidence on the nonlinear relationship between media coverage probability and relief.

7.6 Table VI: News and Relief and Table VII: Robustness

Read: Table VI presents OLS and IV estimates of the effect of news coverage on relief. Table VII reports robustness checks with alternative samples, variables, and specifications.

Economic message: The IV estimates imply that news coverage has a large effect on relief. The robustness table shows that the result is not driven by one weighting scheme or sample choice.

TABLE VI DEPENDENT VARIABLE: <i>Relief</i>							
	OLS				IV		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
News	0.2886 (0.0200)***	0.158 (0.0232)***	0.1309 (0.0178)***	0.2323 (0.0328)***	0.2611 (0.0568)***	0.8237 (0.2028)***	0.6341 (0.3341)*
News* <i>abs(Prnews)</i> >0.5)				−0.4922 (0.1059)***	−0.302 (0.0840)***		0.6768 (0.3554)***
<i>abs(Prnews)</i> >0.5)				0.5374 (0.0943)***	0.2959 (0.0831)***		
<i>log Killed</i>		0.0496 (0.0046)***				0.0198 (0.0208)	
<i>log Affected</i>		0.0358 (0.0024)***				0.0299 (0.0048)***	
Imputed <i>log Killed</i>			0.0378 (0.0038)***	0.0546 (0.0049)***	0.0307 (0.0046)***		0.0109 (0.0132)
Imputed <i>log Affected</i>			0.0375 (0.0020)***	0.0445 (0.0022)***	0.0345 (0.0026)***		0.0292 (0.0045)***
F-stat, instruments, 1st stage						11.0	6.1
Over-id restrictions, $\chi^2(p\text{-value})$						0.51(0.47)	0.64(0.42)
Observations	5,212	2,995	5,212	5,212	5,027	5,212	2,926
R-squared	0.2443	0.4225	0.3800	0.3860			

All regressions include year, month, country, and disaster type fixed effects. Regressions with imputed values (3), (4) and (5) also include fixed effects for the interaction of missing values and disaster type. Robust standard errors in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent. ** Significant at 5 percent. *** Significant at 1 percent.

(a) Table VI: News and Relief.

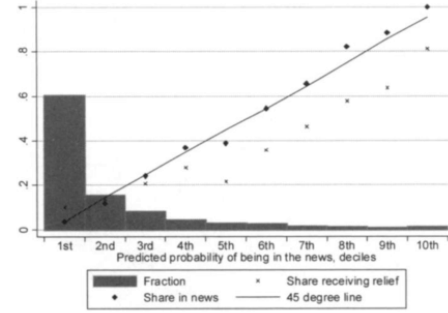


FIGURE V
Probability of a Disaster being in the News and Actual Share: Disasters Receiving Relief

(b) Figure V: predicted probability of news and actual relief share.

TABLE VII ROBUSTNESS					
	Reference	Changes in independent variables			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Reduced form regressions. Dependent variable: <i>News</i>					
<i>News Pressure</i>	−0.0163 (0.0041)***	−0.0157 (0.0040)***	−0.0124 (0.0042)***	−0.0133 (0.0033)***	−0.0155 (0.0036)***
<i>Olympics</i>	−0.1079 (0.0470)**	−0.1085 (0.0469)**	−0.1114 (0.0470)**	−0.1125 (0.0470)**	−0.1156 (0.0470)**
Observations	5,212	5,212	5,212	5,212	5,212
R-squared	0.1797	0.1789	0.1779	0.1789	0.1795
F-test (instr.)	11.05	10.5	7.4	11.19	12.3
Reduced form regressions. Dependent variable: <i>Relief</i>					
<i>News Pressure</i>	−0.0119 (0.0045)***	−0.0116 (0.0045)***	−0.0104 (0.0046)**	−0.0092 (0.0038)**	−0.0085 (0.0041)**
<i>Olympics</i>	−0.1232 (0.0521)**	−0.1235 (0.0521)**	−0.1250 (0.0520)**	−0.1266 (0.0521)**	−0.1182 (0.0515)**
Observations	5,212	5,212	5,212	5,212	5,212
R-squared	0.1989	0.1989	0.1986	0.1987	0.1985
IV-regressions. Dependent variable: <i>Relief</i>					
<i>News</i>	0.8237 (0.2528)***	0.8351 (0.2595)***	0.9391 (0.3225)***	0.8012 (0.2561)***	0.6726 (0.2341)***
Observations	5,212	5,212	5,212	5,212	5,212
Over-id test	0.51 ₁ (0.47)	0.47 ₁ (0.49)	0.66 ₁ (0.66)	0.61 ₁ (0.43)	1.27 ₁ (0.26)

Tables VI and VII (see the last row). In other words, the IV estimates using *news pressure* only as an instrument produce a similar coefficient estimate as the IV estimates instrumenting

(b) Table VII: Robustness, part 1.

The main IV table and the first robustness table are placed together because they jointly establish the magnitude and stability of the media effect.

TABLE VII
ROBUSTNESS (continued)

	Different samples			Probit	
	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)
Reduced form regressions. Dependent variable: <i>News</i>					
<i>News Pressure</i>	-0.0193 (0.0052)***	-0.137 (0.0039)***	-0.242 (0.0118)**	-0.0156 (.0041)***	-0.0984 (0.0273)***
<i>Olympics</i>	-0.1008 (0.0572)*	-0.1199 (0.0451)***	-0.1320 (0.0864)	-0.1206 (0.0428)***	-0.5902 (0.3084)*
Observations	3,950	6,303	3,473	5,209	4,266
R-squared	0.1862	0.1887	0.2072		
F-test (instr.)	8.6	10.3	3.4		
Reduced form regressions. Dependent variable: <i>Relief</i>					
<i>News Pressure</i>	-0.0126 (0.0054)**	-0.0105 (0.0038)***	-0.0125 (0.0142)		-0.0611 (0.0233)***
<i>Olympics</i>	-0.1338 (0.0583)**	-0.0984 (0.0421)**	-0.1767 (0.0893)**		-0.6471 (0.3200)**
Observations	3,950	6,303	3,473		5,209
R-squared	0.1835	0.2208	0.2271		
IV-regressions. Dependent variable: <i>Relief</i>				IV-Probit	Bi-Probit
<i>News</i>	0.7561 (0.2581)***	0.7846 (0.2366)***	0.8505 (0.4597)*	3.1735 (0.4417)***	1.9463 (0.2246)***
Observations	3,910	6,303	3,446	5,209	5,212
Over-id test	1.10 ₁ (0.30)	0.01 ₁ (0.92)	0.85 ₁ (0.36)		

Robust standard errors in parentheses: * significant at 10 percent; ** significant at 5 percent; ***

Table VII continued: robustness across alternative samples and probit specifications.

7.7 Table VIII: Newsworthiness of Disasters, by Disaster Type and Table IX: Newsworthiness of Disasters, by Continents

Read: Table VIII estimates how newsworthiness varies across disaster types. Table IX estimates how newsworthiness varies across continents.

Economic message: These tables show that media attention is systematically biased. Some disasters and regions need many more casualties to obtain the same coverage probability as more newsworthy disasters or regions.

TABLE VIII
NEWSWORTHINESS OF DISASTERS, BY DISASTER TYPE

	Share in news	(SE)	Fixed effects	(SE)	Equal coverage casualties ratio*
Volcano	0.30	(0.05)	0.64	(0.09)	1
Earthquake	0.33	(0.02)	0.59	(**)	2
Fire	0.14	(0.03)	0.49	(0.09)	12
Storm	0.14	(0.01)	0.30	(0.03)	280
Flood	0.09	(0.01)	0.25	(0.03)	674
Landslide	0.07	(0.01)	0.23	(0.03)	882
Epidemic	0.02	(0.01)	0.19	(0.03)	1,696
Drought	0.04	(0.01)	0.17	(0.07)	2,395
Cold wave	0.06	(0.02)	0.15	(0.07)	3,150
Food shortage	0.03	(0.03)	0.00	(0.10)	38,920

The fixed effects regression includes *log killed*, *log affected*, and country, year, and month fixed effects.
* To have the same estimated probability of being covered by the television network news, a food shortage

TABLE IX
NEWSWORTHINESS OF DISASTERS, BY CONTINENTS

	Share in news	(SE)	Fixed effects	(SE)	Equal coverage casualties ratio*
Europe	0.18	(0.02)	0.25	(**)	1
S. and C. America	0.18	(0.01)	0.19	(0.04)	3
Asia	0.13	(0.01)	0.04	(0.04)	43
Africa	0.04	(0.01)	0.04	(0.04)	45
Pacific	0.03	(0.01)	0.00	(0.04)	91

The fixed effects regression includes *log killed*, *log affected*, and disaster type, year, and month fixed effects. * To have the same estimated probability of being covered by the Television Network News, a disaster in the Pacific must have 91 times as many casualties as one in Europe, all else equal (disaster type, year, month, and number affected). ** Europe is the omitted continent.

(a) Table VIII: Newsworthiness of disasters, by disaster type.

(b) Table IX: Newsworthiness of disasters, by continents.

The two newsworthiness tables quantify systematic media bias by event type and region.

7.8 Table X: News Broadcasts on August 5, 1968

Read: Table X lists the main segments of the August 5, 1968 network news broadcasts. It illustrates how the authors construct news pressure from the actual content of television news.

Economic message: This appendix table makes the mechanism concrete. News broadcasts have limited time; when many segments are devoted to major stories, less time is available for foreign disasters.

TABLE X NEWS BROADCASTS ON AUGUST 5, 1968	
	Length(s)
ABC	
Introduction Frank Reynolds (Miami Beach)	10
Eisenhower Heart Attack/Republican National Conv	130
Republican National Convention/Reagan/Rockefeller/Nixon	160
(Commercial: Johnson's Off Insect Repellent; Pledge Furniture Wax)	60
Republican National Convention/Nixon	200
CBS	
Introduction Walter Cronkite (Miami Beach); Charles Kuralt (New York City)	10
Eisenhower Health/Nixon	170
(Commercial: Old Gold and Spring 100 Cigarettes)	50
Republican National Convention/Nixon	180
Convention/Reagan	80
NBC	
Introduction Chet Huntley (Miami Beach); David Brinkley (Miami Beach)	10
Republican National Convention/Nixon/Reagan/Rockefeller	380
Convention/Money/Stassen	30
(Commercial: Geritol Tablets and Liquid; Serutan Laxative)	70
Convention Candidates/Nixon/Rockefeller/Reagan	190

Table X: News Broadcasts on August 5, 1968.

8 Short summary

- The paper studies roughly 5,000 natural disasters from 1968 to 2002.
- About one-fifth receive U.S. disaster relief and about one-tenth receive network news coverage.
- News coverage is endogenous because severe and salient disasters are more likely to be covered.
- The authors use Olympics timing and other news pressure as instruments for disaster news coverage.
- Unrelated news crowds out disaster coverage.
- News crowd-out reduces the probability of U.S. relief.
- IV estimates imply that news coverage has a large causal effect on relief.
- Instruments are not correlated with disaster severity.
- Media bias favors more visually dramatic disaster types and some regions.
- The paper shows that humanitarian policy is partly shaped by media scarcity.

9 Conclusion

9.1 Core conclusion

Eisensee and Strömberg show that television news coverage causally affects U.S. disaster relief. Foreign disasters that occur during news-heavy periods are less likely to receive coverage and less likely to receive relief, even though the competing news is unrelated to the disaster’s severity.

9.2 Incremental contribution revisited

The paper’s key incremental contribution is its research design. By using unrelated news pressure as an instrument, it provides unusually clean evidence that media coverage influences policy decisions. It also quantifies how media scarcity creates biases in the allocation of humanitarian aid.

9.3 Economic intuition

Government attention is limited, and public attention is shaped by the news. When a disaster is not covered, it is less salient to citizens, bureaucrats, and policy makers. Therefore, relief decisions respond not only to need but also to the supply of available news time.

9.4 Policy implication

Relief agencies and governments should not rely on media attention as a sufficient signal of need. A systematic procedure that uses objective disaster severity measures could reduce distortions caused by news droughts and news floods.

9.5 Limitations

The instruments estimate effects for disasters whose coverage is shifted by news pressure. The results concern U.S. foreign disaster relief and network television during 1968-2002, so magnitudes may differ in the internet and social-media era.

9.6 Takeaway

The paper demonstrates that mass media can influence public spending decisions through agenda-setting and crowd-out. When news time is scarce, the victims of less visible disasters can lose relief.